Incident Response & Escalation Runbook

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1. Purpose

This runbook provides a structured approach for identifying, recording, tracking, escalating, and resolving IT incidents in a simulated enterprise technology environment.

It aims to ensure that incidents are managed consistently, responsibilities are clearly defined, and stakeholders receive timely information.

Key Objectives:

- Ensure consistent incident tracking and documentation.
- Minimize the potential impact of operational incidents.
- Establish clear ownership and escalation procedures.
- Improve communication across technical and business teams.
- Maintain accurate records for reporting and continuous improvement.

2. Scope

This runbook covers simulated incidents involving:

- Application availability and performance
- Authentication and access issues
- Network and infrastructure failures
- Database and API performance degradation
- Monitoring alerts and service disruptions
- Security-related operational incidents

This document focuses on incident coordination and tracking rather than independent technical remediation or risk approval.

3. Incident Severity Classification

The following severity levels are illustrative and intended for training purposes.

Severity	Definition	Example
SEV 1 — Critical	Major service disruption affecting critical business operations	Core banking application unavailable
SEV 2 — High	Significant service degradation affecting important functions	Multiple users unable to log in
SEV 3 — Medium	Limited operational impact with a workaround available	Intermittent API performance issues
SEV 4 — Low	Minor issue with limited business impact	Noncritical monitoring alert

Incident severity and Jira priority should be evaluated separately. A ticket's priority may depend on urgency, business impact, and delivery requirements.

4. Incident Management Lifecycle

Step 1 — Incident Identification

Incidents may be identified through:

- Monitoring alerts
- User-reported issues
- Application support notifications
- Infrastructure monitoring
- Security event notifications

Record the initial information, including the affected service, symptoms, time detected, and reporting source.

Step 2 — Incident Logging

Create or update the relevant Jira ticket.

Required Information:

- Incident summary
- Affected service or application
- Incident description
- Detection time
- Severity and priority
- Assigned owner

- Current status
- Business impact
- Next action and due date

Step 3 — Initial Assessment

The responsible technical team should assess:

1. Which service is affected?
2. What is the potential business impact?
3. How many users or systems may be affected?
4. Is a workaround available?
5. Does the incident require immediate escalation?

The IT Operations Coordinator records findings and follows up with the responsible teams.

Step 4 — Investigation and Coordination

The assigned technical team investigates the incident.

The IT Operations Coordinator supports by:

- Tracking investigation progress.
- Following up with responsible teams.
- Recording outstanding dependencies.
- Updating Jira tickets.
- Preparing stakeholder status updates.
- Escalating significant delays or blockers.

Step 5 — Blocker Management

If an investigation cannot proceed:

1. Change the ticket status to Blocked.
2. Document the blocker and its operational impact.
3. Identify the blocker owner.
4. Define the next action and follow-up deadline.
5. Notify the relevant stakeholders.
6. Escalate when necessary.

Step 6 — Resolution and Validation

Before closing an incident:

- The responsible technical team confirms the corrective action.
- Service recovery or the agreed resolution outcome is validated.
- Remaining risks or follow-up items are documented.

- Relevant stakeholders are informed.
- Completion evidence is recorded in Jira.

Only authorized personnel should approve production changes, formal risk acceptance, or other controlled technical decisions.

Step 7 — Incident Closure

The ticket may move to Done when the completion criteria are satisfied and the responsible team confirms closure.

Record:

- Resolution summary
- Validation evidence
- Resolution or closure date
- Remaining follow-up actions, if any
- Related problem or change records, where applicable

5. Escalation Procedure

Escalation is required when an incident cannot be resolved through normal coordination or when its impact exceeds the responsible team's authority.

Escalation Triggers

- Critical or widespread service disruption
- Significant business or customer impact
- Potential security or data protection concerns
- Missing approvals affecting critical operations
- Unresolved blockers threatening important deadlines
- Insufficient resources or technical ownership

Escalation Matrix

Level	Responsible Role	Typical Responsibility
Level 1	IT Operations Coordinator	Record, track, and communicate incidents
Level 2	Application / Infrastructure Support Team	Perform technical investigation and remediation
Level 3	IT Operations Lead / Incident Manager	Coordinate significant incidents and resolve escalation issues

Level 4	Authorized Technology Management / Risk Owner	Handle decisions requiring higher authority

The matrix is illustrative. Actual escalation paths and response targets must follow the organization's approved procedures.

6. Stakeholder Communication Guidelines

Incident status updates should include:

- Incident ID
- Affected service
- Current status
- Business impact
- Investigation progress
- Outstanding blockers
- Responsible owner
- Next action
- Expected next update

Updates should distinguish confirmed findings from assumptions.

Communication Template

Subject: Incident Status Update — [Incident ID]

Incident: [Incident Summary]

Current Status: [To Do / In Progress / Blocked / Done]

Impact: [Affected services and business impact]

Progress: [Latest confirmed findings]

Blocker: [Outstanding dependency, if applicable]

Owner: [Responsible Team]

Next Action: [Required action]

Next Update: [Date / Time]

7. Practical Example — IDBO-4

Ticket: IDBO-4 — Investigate API response time degradation

Current Status: Blocked

Priority: High

Issue Description:

A simulated banking application is experiencing increased API response times during peak usage periods.

Current Blocker:

The investigation is waiting for API performance logs from the Infrastructure Team.

Responsible Team: Infrastructure Team

Impact:

The application support team cannot complete the investigation until the required logs are available. The potential service impact remains under assessment.

Next Actions:

1. Follow up with the Infrastructure Team.
2. Obtain the required performance logs.
3. Coordinate review with the Application Support Team.
4. Record confirmed findings in Jira.
5. Escalate if the dependency threatens the agreed deadline.

Follow-up Date: 02 November 2026

Due Date: 04 November 2026

Expected Outcome:

The responsible technical team identifies the likely cause or confirms the next investigation step, and the ticket is updated with the appropriate resolution actions.

Type	Key	Summary	Assignee	Priority	Status	Updated
☑	IDBO-4	Investigate API response time degradation	Peter Phan	High	Blocked	Oct 30, 2026, 11:23

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8. Incident Documentation Standards

Every incident ticket should contain:

- Clear incident description
- Severity and priority
- Assigned owner
- Relevant timestamps
- Business or technical impact
- Investigation updates
- Blocker and escalation information

- Resolution evidence
- Closure summary

Incomplete information should be identified and followed up during daily Jira hygiene reviews.

9. Post-Incident Review

For significant incidents, a post-incident review may be conducted to identify improvement opportunities.

Recommended review topics:

- Incident timeline
- Detection and response effectiveness
- Root cause, if established
- Communication effectiveness
- Escalation challenges
- Preventive and corrective actions
- Responsible owners and follow-up dates

Actions identified during the review should be tracked through Jira.

10. Related Jira Work Items

- IDBO-1 — Investigate intermittent login failures
- IDBO-4 — Investigate API response time degradation
- IDBO-11 — Investigate batch payment processing delay
- IDBO-14 — Review monitoring alert noise

Type	Key	Summary	Assignee	Priority	Status	Updated
☑	IDBO-1	Investigate intermittent login failures	Peter Phan	High	To Do	Oct 30, 2026, 13:38

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Type	Key	Summary	Assignee	Priority	Status	Updated
☑	IDBO-4	Investigate API response time degradation	Peter Phan	High	Blocked	Oct 30, 2026, 11:23

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Type	Key	Summary	Assignee	Priority	Status	Updated
☑	IDBO-11	Investigate batch payment processing delay	Peter Phan	Highest	In Progress	Oct 30, 2026, 11:28

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Type	Key	Summary	Assignee	Priority	Status	Updated
☑	IDBO-14	Review monitoring alert noise	Peter Phan	Medium	Blocked	Oct 30, 2026, 11:33

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11. Continuous Improvement

The incident management process should be periodically reviewed to:

- Improve escalation clarity.
- Reduce delayed incident follow-ups.
- Improve operational documentation.
- Identify recurring incidents.
- Reduce unnecessary monitoring alerts.
- Strengthen communication and reporting quality.

Disclaimer: This runbook is a training simulation. It does not represent HSBC's internal incident management procedures, actual response commitments, or authorized operational controls.